

GETTY IMAGES

sort to rest on his laurels. "*Jab tak mujhe nahin lagega ki haan 100 per cent ho gaya hai*, I cannot improve more than this. Until then, I will keep working hard and be passionate about the sport," says the 26-year-old in *The Road Less Taken*, a three-part INDIA TODAY documentary on the javelin-thrower's journey.

That meticulousness has paid rich dividends on field. Since he became Olympic champion, Chopra has added more firsts to his name—first Indian to be a world champion in athletics (2023) and first to win the prestigious Diamond League final (2022). Each conversation around his stupendous form, though, ultimately ends with "When will he enter the elite 90-metre club?" For Chopra, it's a desirable target but not something he loses sleep over. "Many of my challengers have crossed 90 metres, but it all depends on the distance you are covering on the given day," he told the media. "Who handles the pressure of the competition on that day? That's the biggest challenge." This year, 13 athletes have already crossed the 85-metre mark, so Chopra's defence of his title will be anything but easy.

Achievements are one thing but what makes a great athlete into a legend is their impact. In the three years since Chopra became India's second Olympic individual gold medalist and, indeed, its first medalist in athletics, the nation has become a powerhouse in javelin throw. It showed on the Asian Games podium in Hangzhou where Kishore Jena joined Chopra, and at the World Championships where the top six had three Indians, including D.P. Manu. In Paris, Chopra won't be alone, he will have Jena for company.

Neeraj heads to Paris with the same team he had in Tokyo–coach Dr Klaus Bartoneitz and physiotherapist Ishan Marwaha. Since Tokyo, he has spent a big chunk of his time training abroad. It's not a cushy life, he will have you know. "*Kaafi logon ko lagta hai ki inke toh maze hain, baahar hi rehte hain. Badi boring life hoti hai* (Many think he's living the high life abroad. In fact, it's very boring)," he says. It's evident in the daily routine: eat, train, rest, train, eat, sleep. "The hostel and dining hall are our boundary, the track is our world."

"JAB TAK MUJHE NAHIN LAGEGA KI 100% HO GAYA HAI (TILL I FEEL I'VE ACHIEVED 100%) AND CAN'T IMPROVE MORE THAN THIS, TILL THEN, I'LL KEEP WORKING HARD AND BE PASSIONATE ABOUT THE SPORT"

— NEERAJ CHOPRA

Expecting a redux of a herculean feat is akin to asking for the moon. The likes of Usain Bolt, Elaine Thompson Herah and Mo Farah have proven that it's possible—by doing double on track in back-to-back Olympics. Like the top athletes, Chopra, too, exhibits fearlessness, self-belief and motivation. It's why Adille Sumariwalla, president of the Athletics Federation of India, heralds him as "the man who changed Indian sport for ever". It's why 1.4 billion people believe that if anybody can do it twice, it's Neeraj. ■

–Suhani Singh